

Islamic Extremism and Bangsamoro Transition

Philippines, Mindanao

SIGNAL

The BARMM campaign period has opened under an unprecedented alignment of counter-terrorism success and political fragmentation, but Manila's sustained neglect of the peace process architecture is converting tactical security gains into strategic political risk.

FRACTURE

Marcos's 40-second SONA treatment of the Bangsamoro peace process and his refusal to address CAB implementation during his BARMM visit reveal that the administration's election strategy is prioritizing aid distribution over institutional peace-building, while Commander Bravo's explicit threat of a return to armed struggle transforms the political rift into a kinetic risk.

The Marcos administration will use the BTA extension to increase Manila's direct influence over BARMM governance, reducing MILF autonomy in the name of election stability.

75%

PROBABILITY

TARGET: MARCH 2027

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM

WHAT'S NEW

- **Campaign period opens (July 30):** The 45-day campaign for the September 14 BARMM parliamentary elections formally began with 631 candidates and 494 party nominees from 13 regional parties vying for 80 seats. 27 areas classified under "red" or "orange" election concern categories by COMELEC. Two BFP candidates in Maguindanao del Norte already assured victory – running unopposed.
- **Marcos BARMM visit – aid without peace (July 22):** Marcos distributed P3.4 billion in projects and assistance (P2.9B from BARMM government, P433M from national government) during his visit to Camp Siongco, Maguindanao del Norte. The visit was postponed from July 21 on Presidential Security Command recommendation. Notably, Marcos did not address the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro or meet MILF leadership, despite the Multisectoral Peace Coalition's pre-visit appeal for formal GPH-MILF dialogue.
- **SONA 2026 sidelines peace process (July 27):** The Bangsamoro peace process received only three paragraphs – 40 seconds in an 86-minute address – focusing narrowly on election logistics. No mention of CAB implementation, decommissioning, normalization, or the MILF's grievances. Civil society groups expressed disappointment; MindaNews headlined: "Bangsamoro peace process merits less than a minute in Marcos' 86-minute SONA."

- **Multisectoral Peace Coalition mobilization (July 1-20):** A new civil society coalition held a peace summit in Davao City (July 1-3), followed by a three-hour dialogue with Peace Adviser Sarmiento (July 20). Sarmiento committed to implementing the peace agreement "in close coordination with the MILF rather than through unilateral government action" and signaled openness to restoring the International Monitoring Team (IMT) and Third Party Facilitator engagement.
- **Commander Bravo escalation (July 2026):** MILF's Commander Bravo publicly warned the MILF is prepared to return to armed struggle if CAB commitments remain unfulfilled – the most explicit threat of a reversion to insurgency from a senior MILF commander since the 2014 peace deal.
- **BFP institutionalized as dominant minority party:** COMELEC Resolution No. 11248 designated UBJP as dominant majority party and BFP as dominant minority party for the September 14 polls – formalizing the political schism within the MILF as an electoral reality.
- **Crisis Group Report #355 (July 2026):** Comprehensive diagnosis of peace deal implementation failures warns stalled CAB could fuel ISIS activity and that educated cadres could form a loosely coordinated jihadist network expanding to urban areas.
- **BARMM opens Lanao del Norte office (July 23):** Symbolic extension of BARMM governance presence outside its formal territory, alongside ongoing MILF Base Command declarations against DI-MG and NPA.
- **Probability change explanation:** No change. The accumulation of evidence since the last report – Marcos's neglect of CAB in both his BARMM visit and SONA, the formalization of the BFP-UBJP schism, Commander Bravo's explicit threat, and Crisis Group's diagnosis – reinforces rather than weakens the prediction. The administration is pursuing a strategy of transactional aid distribution without institutional peace-building, consistent with eventual BTA extension under Manila-dictated terms.

ANALYSIS

POLITICAL

The political landscape has undergone a qualitative shift since the last report. What was previously characterized as MILF "fragmentation" has now solidified into an institutionalized dual-party system within BARMM politics. COMELEC's formal designation of UBJP as "dominant majority" and BFP as "dominant minority" transforms the schism from an internal MILF crisis into an electoral structure that Manila can manage and leverage.

Marcos's behavior in late July is the most telling indicator of administration intent. His BARMM visit (July 22) distributed P3.4 billion – 85% of which was BARMM government money, not national funds – while pointedly avoiding any engagement with the CAB implementation agenda or MILF leadership. The Presidential Security Command's last-minute postponement from July 21, without cited threat, raised questions about whether the delay

reflected security concerns or political calculus. Five days later, his SONA devoted 40 seconds to the peace process out of 86 minutes – less time than was given to coconut tree planting targets. This is not oversight; it is signal.

The Multisectoral Peace Coalition's rapid mobilization and Sarmiento's conciliatory commitments (July 20 dialogue) represent a counterweight. Sarmiento's pledge to restore the IMT and proceed "in close coordination with the MILF" suggests the peace bureaucracy understands the danger. But whether Sarmiento can deliver against the apparent preferences of Malacañang remains unproven. The Sarmiento-Iqbal counterpart relationship (formalized July 15) provides an institutional channel, but one that exists in tension with the administration's demonstrated preference for aid-over-architecture.

Commander Bravo's threat to return to armed struggle is not rhetorical theater. It is the most explicit warning from the MILF's armed wing since the CAB was signed in 2014, and it reflects the growing perception within MILF ranks that Manila is dismantling the peace deal through neglect and unilateral action. The MILF Central Committee's suspension of Macacua as BIAF Chief of Staff (June 2026) and the subsequent BFP defections have created a situation where the MILF's political and armed wings are under separate, potentially competing leadership – a fragmentation pattern that historically precedes violence in insurgent-to-political transitions.

ECONOMIC

The economic dimensions of the BARMM transition continue to deteriorate in ways that feed both political and security risks. The P3.4 billion convergence program distribution (July 22) was structured overwhelmingly from BARMM's own budget (P2.9B), with only P433M from the national government – a ratio that exposes the fiscal weakness of Manila's commitment. Meanwhile, the UNODC TOCTA 2026 report documents how illicit tobacco trade is funding non-state armed groups, and the Sulu-Celebes maritime crime corridor persists as a revenue stream for ASG remnants and BIFF splinters.

The Hormuz energy shock continues to impose macro-fiscal constraints on Manila, contributing to defense budget pressure and reducing bandwidth for BARMM economic development. The P1.23B fund for education and social protection in BARMM (announced alongside July's convergence program) and the P38.86M housing assistance for former combatants represent genuine investments, but they are dwarfed by the scale of need in a region where 40,000 MILF combatants were to be decommissioned under CAB and reintegration programs remain suspended over OPAPRU failures.

The BARMM Board of Investments reported reaching 75% of its P3.2B investment target by March 2026 (P2.4B in Q1 alone), suggesting private sector confidence exists beneath the political turbulence. But the election period – with its prohibition on public works, hiring, and fund disbursement – will freeze government spending from July 16 through September 29, effectively pausing economic activity during the campaign and immediate post-election period. For a region under state of calamity from overlapping crises (oil, drought, earthquake), this freeze compounds humanitarian stress.

MILITARY

The military dimension presents the most complex picture. On the tactical level, AFP-WestMinCom operations have achieved remarkable results: the July 5 neutralization of BIFF-Bungos leader Esmael Abubakar, alongside DI-Hassan leader Emarudin Kulaw, DI-Maute leader Amerol Mangoranca, and CTG's Anthony Narvasa, represents the most significant decapitation of terrorist leadership in Mindanao since the 2017 Marawi siege. Combined with the CARES framework operations in Basilan (July 15 onward) and MILF Base Command declarations against DI-MG and NPA (May-June), the counter-terrorism picture appears favorable heading into the election.

However, three structural risks offset these tactical gains:

First, Commander Bravo's threat transforms the MILF from a counter-terrorism partner into a potential adversary. The MILF-Army joint anti-ISIS front forged in Munai (May 23) could unravel if the political rift deepens, removing the most effective ground-level intelligence and interdiction asset against ISIS-affiliated cells.

Second, the Crisis Group's warning about educated cadres forming a loosely coordinated jihadist network that could expand to urban areas represents a qualitative evolution of the threat. The ISIS-claimed Munai ambush (January 23, 4 soldiers killed) and the Dalandang assassination on the first day of the gun ban (July 16) demonstrate that even with leadership decapitation, operational capacity persists at the cell level.

Third, the RSIS Global Terrorism Forecast 2026 confirmation that the Bondi Beach attackers trained in Mindanao (November 2025) and that Davao City functions as an FTF hub reinforces the Philippines' designation as a "terrorism academy in Asia." The porous Sulu-Celebes maritime corridor documented by UNODC facilitates the movement of foreign fighters, weapons, and illicit commodities that fund extremist operations. The 27 areas now under red/orange election concern classification represent a security challenge that the 7,991 deployed PNP personnel may struggle to contain, particularly given the Army's simultaneous commitments to South China Sea patrols and post-earthquake disaster response.

TECHNOLOGICAL

Technology trends cut in opposing directions. The UNOCT CT TECH+ workshop (June 4-5) and INTERPOL partnership represent international capacity-building on counter-terrorism technology, and the COMELEC's deployment of 6,500 automated counting machines with contingency units suggests the electoral infrastructure is technically prepared. LENTE (Legal Network for Truthful Elections) has deployed long-term observers monitoring disinformation alongside traditional electoral violations – a recognition that information warfare is a primary risk vector.

On the threat side, the educated cadres jihadist network flagged by Crisis Group implies sophisticated use of encrypted communications and social media for recruitment and coordination, potentially beyond the current capacity of Philippine cyber-monitoring. The UNODC's documentation of the crime-terror nexus in the Sulu-Celebes corridor – where cannabis, cocaine, firearms, and cigarettes move through the same smuggling networks –

suggests encrypted coordination platforms facilitate both criminal and extremist logistics.

The broader concern is the intersection of AI-enabled disinformation with the BARMM election. The ANFREL/NDI pre-campaign statement (July 30) flagged voter education as "an immediate priority," particularly given the novelty of the parliamentary system for a population that has never voted under it. If disinformation campaigns exploit this information asymmetry – whether through AI-generated content, manipulated media, or coordinated inauthentic behavior – they could undermine the legitimacy of results regardless of the technical integrity of the voting process.

Critically for the prediction, COMELEC's central role in managing electoral technology – including the 6,500 automated counting machines, their software specifications, and the transmission of results – gives Manila a technical lever over the electoral outcome that can be amplified by the election period restrictions on local government hiring and fund disbursement. Any post-election technical disputes over transmission delays, shading thresholds, or machine malfunctions in BARMM could serve as justification for the BTA extension narrative that MILF autonomy requires closer Manila supervision. This technical dependency is the least visible but potentially most durable instrument of central government influence over the transition.

WATCH INDICATORS

- Campaign period violence trends (July 30–September 12), particularly in the 27 red/orange areas
- Whether Marcos or Sarmiento convenes formal GPH-MILF dialogue before the September 14 election
- BFP vs. UBJP candidate slates and campaign rhetoric – specifically any escalation to armed mobilization language
- Commander Bravo faction cohesion and any BIAF operational movements during the campaign period
- ISIS-affiliated group activity, particularly any claimed attacks during the election period
- International observer assessments (ANFREL/NDI, LENTE) of campaign conduct and election integrity
- Post-election transition: whether the BTA is extended, restructured, or dissolved as of October 30, 2026

PROBABILITY TRIGGERS

EVENT	DIRECTION
Marcos administration announces BTA extension with new Manila-appointed oversight powers	Up
Formal GPH-MILF dialogue resumes with concrete CAB implementation milestones before election day	Down
Major election-related violence involving MILF factions disrupts September 14 polls	Up
BFP wins parliamentary majority or enough seats to form coalition government, sidelining UBJP	Up
International mediators broker a pre-election power-sharing agreement preserving MILF autonomy	Down
BIAF elements initiate armed action in response to perceived CAB violations	Up
COMELEC-certified peaceful elections with clear MILF participation and acceptance of results	Down
Sarmiento delivers on IMT restoration and Third Party Facilitator re-engagement before October 30	Down

KEY SOURCES

1. Bangsamoro peace process merits less than a minute in Marcos' 86-minute SONA – MindaNews (July 27, 2026)
2. Marcos leads distribution of P3.4B worth of projects to BARMM but mum on peace process – MindaNews (July 23, 2026)
3. Peace in the Philippines: The Bangsamoro's Moment of Truth – Crisis Group Report #355 (July 2026)
4. BARMM transition strained by peace deal implementation issues – Rappler (July 2026)
5. Peace coalition urges Marcos to reaffirm support for Bangsamoro peace process in SONA – CoverStory (July 24, 2026)
6. BARMM kicks off campaign period for parliamentary polls; 27 areas under red/orange concern – SunStar (July 30, 2026)
7. BIFF-Bungos faction leader killed in clash – SunStar Zamboanga (July 5, 2026)
8. ANFREL-NDI Joint Pre-Campaign Statement on the 2026 BARMM Parliamentary Elections (July 30, 2026)
9. Global Terrorism Forecast 2026 – RSIS (January 2026)

